Zhiqin "Bill" Qian

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Education

Rice University **Houston, TX**

PhD student, Computer Science, Advisor: Vaibhav Unhelkar, GPA: 4.00/4.00 *May 2023 - Present*

BA, Computer Science, GPA: 3.95/4.00, Magna Cum Laude *Aug 2019 - May 2023*

- Research Interests: Human-AI Interaction, Value Alignment, Reinforcement Learning
- Relevant Coursework: Algorithms and Data Structures, Reinforcement Learning, Deep Learning for Vision and Language, Bayesian Statistics, Convex Optimization, Analysis, Linear Algebra, Sciences of the Mind
- Honors: Distinction in Research and Creative Work (2023), President's Honor Roll (2019, 2021)

Research Experience

May 2021 - Present: Research Assistant, *Human-AI Teaming Lab, Rice University*, Houston, TX

May 2020 – Jan 2021: Research Assistant, *Treangen Lab, Rice University*, Houston, TX

Publications

1. Qian, Z.*, Diaz, R., Seo, S. and Unhelkar, V. "Hierarchical Reward Design from Language: Enhancing Alignment of Agent Behavior with Human Specifications." *International Conference on Autonomous Agents and Multiagent Systems (AAMAS)*, 2026.
2. Seo, S., Qian, Z. and Unhelkar, V. "AI-Assisted Coordination of Human Teams in Situated Tasks." *Proceedings of the AAAI Symposium Series (AAAI Symposium)*, 2025.
3. Qian, Z.*, Orlov-Savko, L.*, Neubauer, C., Gremillion, G., Unhelkar, V. "Measuring Variations in Workload during Human-Robot Collaboration through Automated After-Action Reviews." *Companion of the ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction (HRI)*, 2024.
4. Orlov-Savko, L.*, Qian, Z.*, Gremillion, G., Neubauer, C., Canady, J., Unhelkar, V. "RW4T Dataset: Data of Human-Robot Behavior and Cognitive States in Simulated Disaster Response Tasks." *ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction (HRI)*, 2024.
5. Balaji, A.*[1], Kille, B.*, Kappell, A. and Godbold, G., Diep, M., Elworth, R., Qian, Z., Albin, D., Nasko, D., Shah, N., Pop, M., Segarra, S., Ternus, K., Treangen, T. "SeqScreen: accurate and sensitive functional screening of pathogenic sequences via ensemble learning." *Genome Biol 23, 133*, 2022.

Teaching

Teaching Assistant, Rice University **Houston, TX**

- Guest lectured twice in *Reinforcement Learning (COMP 552)*
- Designed the final exam for *Reinforcement Learning (COMP 552)*
- Led office hours and graded homework assignments and exams for other courses

Courses Assisted

- *Reinforcement Learning (COMP 552)* Fall 2023, Fall 2025
- *Artificial Intelligence (COMP 557)* Spring 2024
- *Algorithmic Thinking (COMP 182)* Spring 2023, Spring 2021
- *Advanced Object-Oriented Programming and Design (COMP 310)* Fall 2022
- *Reasoning About Algorithms (COMP 382)* Fall 2021

Volunteering

Office of Academic Advising, Rice University **Houston, TX**

Peer Academic Advisor *Feb 2020 - May 2023*

- Oversaw and coordinated academic advising programs during orientation week for 100+ new students.
- Held monthly office hours to help students navigate through academic procedures and resources.